

who pay taxes that aid in the development of such fonts, and not the body that developed it, using taxpayers' money.

So, if I go by their licence agreement when I want to download a font, I will have to agree to: "1. These Products are for Academic/R&D/Personnel use only." Then another restrictive clause: "3. Copies of the Software and the manual can be made only for back-up purposes and non-commercial personal products/utilities/fonts usage. Any copy made must include all copyright and proprietary information notices appearing on the copy provided herein. Such a copy, if later on used for commercial purposes, will be treated as illegal."

What if I want to use these fonts for my commercial website? Not being permitted to do so, according to me, is against the principles of the free software philosophy.

According to the FSF, "Free software does not mean non-commercial. A free program must be available for commercial use, commercial development, and commercial distribution. Commercial development of free software is no longer unusual; such free commercial software is very important. You may have paid money to get copies of free software, or you may have obtained copies at no charge. But regardless of how you got your copies, you always have the freedom to copy and change the software, even to sell copies." (www.gnu.org/philosophy/selling.html)

But all the conditions for the 'government approved' font are quite contradictory to the FSF's philosophy.

(Editorial team's note: Even if you want to disregard the principles of free software and what the FSF preaches, I guess we agree that if it's developed with the aid of funds from the taxpayers' money, it should be in the public domain. Period!)

This may lead to many more complex situations as this font is not at all compatible with the GPL, or any of the other free software, for that matter. Thus, even the government bodies won't be able to use these fonts with a lot of free and open source software (FOSS) they apparently deploy and implement.

When asked how appropriate the move was and what would be the ideal situation for choosing fonts for official work, Richard Stallman said, "It is flagrant injustice for the government to distribute useful information (such as software or fonts) to the public with these restrictions."

He added, "We tried for years to get the CDAC fonts to be freed, but I think they never did so." In the end, he warns that, "Fonts are works of practical functional use, so their users deserve the four freedoms. Furthermore, fonts today normally take the form of software, so a non-free font is non-free software."

I am curious; when the font does not comply with

the free software philosophy and slaps restrictions on users, then: (1) How can those officials sitting in the apex bodies choose it, knowing it is not truly 'free' in nature; and (2) How can an organisation like TDIL (which is supposed to serve the public interest) release software under such restrictive terms and conditions — which they call a licence.

The reason I've honed in on TDIL is that it is a programme started by the Department of Information Technology (DIT), with an aim to develop information processing tools to facilitate human machine interaction in Indian languages, and to develop technologies to access multi-lingual knowledge resources.

It is also debatable if the Union government is even concerned about free software at all. It was the opposition parties who argued against the software patent deal—and the CPI(M) took the lead in that. Also, the BJP, though infamous for its religious dogma, supports free and open source in a big way by going as far as building their whole party IT infrastructure on FOSS. It's a shame that the recent activities by government bodies shun the opportunities of freedom—or do they say no to FOSS only because the opposition had said "Yes" to it?

Bhuvan: Continue to pay *jagaan* to Microsoft

ISRO recently released Bhuvan and the entire nation has gone gaga over it. However, ISRO seems to believe that there are no other operating systems besides Windows—or do they think that this is all Indians are capable of using? This is ironic, considering that the government-funded CDAC has its own GNU/Linux operating system called BOSS. So, it appears that CDAC is being BOSSed around by proprietary and non-free counterparts.

According to an ISRO press release, "The Bhuvan geospatial enables users to access information on basic natural resources in the geospatial domain, particularly the Indian images and thematic information in multiple spatial resolutions. This would provide a sharper picture of Indian terrain barring sensitive locations such as military and nuclear installations."

It also says that there would be many more value-added functions and facilities that will be added into the package from time to time. "A particular interest of ISRO/DOS would be to provide such functionalities to the common man so that he/she adopts a participatory approach with scientists to solve simple problems easily and interactively."

But, how did ISRO figure out that the common man of India uses only Microsoft Windows, because if you go to the Bhuvan site, you will be welcomed with a garland that says, "View in IE 6.0 or above only with 1280 x 1024 resolution."

And here're the system requirements to run Bhuvan:

- Operating system: Windows XP/Vista